◆ PREPARED FOR MARINA · NOVEMBER 2026

Abu Dhabi and Dubai: a clear guide for your AED 5M

There's a lot of noise about the UAE property market right now, and much of it contradicts itself. This guide cuts it down to what actually matters for your budget: how the two cities compare, what protects your money, and which homes make sense.

The short version

- Both cities are safe, regulated places to buy. Which one suits you depends on what you want the home to do for you.
- **Dubai** is the bigger, more established market, with more choice and more homes being completed right now.
- **Abu Dhabi** is earlier in its story: more people arriving than homes being built, and payment plans that ask for less money before you receive the keys.

What's happening in each market

	ABU DHABI	DUBAI
Home sales, first half of 2026	Up 178% on last year	Down 16% on last year
New homes coming	Around 37,000 over the next four years	Around 27,300 completed in one quarter this year
People arriving	Around 288,000 in a year - roughly 18 for every new home sold	Roughly 2 for every new home sold
Rents	Up 17% in a year, 21% on the islands	Steadying, with some prices easing 5-7%
Paid before you get the keys	Usually 35-50%	Usually 60-80%
Who stands behind the developers	The government's sovereign funds, around US$1.9 trillion	Dubai's government holding company, Dubai Holding

What protects your money - in both cities

Escrow. Your payments go into a regulated account, not to the developer, and are released only as construction progresses and is verified.

Government-backed developers. Every developer in this guide is owned or majority-owned by the state.

Staged payments. You never pay the full price up front - you pay in steps as the building goes up.

Registered ownership. Your purchase is recorded with the government land registry from day one.

Five terms, in plain English

Off-plan - buying a home before it's finished, usually at a lower price.

Payment plan (e.g. 40/60) - 40% paid during construction, 60% when you receive the keys.

Handover - the day the home is finished and yours to use or rent.

Cancellation unit - a home released back to the developer and offered again, often the only way into a project that has sold out.

Escrow - the protected account your payments sit in while the building goes up.

Sources: Cavendish Maxwell H1 2026 · Knight Frank · SCAD · ADREC H1 2026 · Savills Q2 2026. Figures indicative, November 2026.

◆ YOUR OPTIONS IN ABU DHABI

Five homes that fit your budget, each suited to a different priority.

HOME	WHERE	WHAT YOU GET	PRICE	PAID BEFORE KEYS	READY
Tara Park MODON	Reem Island, opposite Reem Mall, 5 minutes from the financial district	3-bed apartment, ~2,000-2,500 sq ft	~AED 3.6-3.7m	40%	Late 2029 - mid 2030
Muheira MODON	Waterfront on Reem Island	3-bed apartment, ~1,950-2,000 sq ft	AED 3.3-4.3m	50%	Late 2028 - mid 2029
Bashayer MODON	Hudayriyat Island, on the beach	2-bed ~1,400-1,600 sq ft, or 3-bed ~2,000 sq ft	2-bed AED 3.05-4.1m · 3-bed from ~AED 3.6m	50%	2029
The Canopies, Yas Point ALDAR	Yas Island waterfront	2-bed + maid's room ~1,500 sq ft	AED 4.2m	To be confirmed	To be confirmed
Manchester City Yas Residences OHANA	Yas Canal	3-bed townhouse ~2,230 sq ft	AED 4.25m	35%	Late 2029

A note on availability. Tara Park, Muheira, Bashayer and Manchester City Yas Residences all sold out at launch. For these, we'd be securing a cancellation unit, so availability and exact price are confirmed home by home. The Canopies is still selling directly.

Which suits you

IF RENTAL INCOME MATTERS MOST

Tara Park. Its tenants are the professionals working in Abu Dhabi's financial district, which grew 34% in a year. It's also the best value per square foot. I bought a 2-bedroom here myself in April.

IF YOU'D LIKE THE KEYS SOONER

Muheira. Ready up to two years earlier than most of the others, on the water.

IF IT'S A HOME YOU'D LOVE TO LIVE IN

Bashayer. A beachfront apartment on Abu Dhabi's flagship island, with the surf park, beach and cycle tracks already open.

IF YOU WANT A HOUSE RATHER THAN AN APARTMENT

Manchester City Yas Residences. A townhouse with its own garage, and the lowest amount to pay before handover.

IF YAS ISLAND IS THE DRAW

The Canopies. Prime waterfront from Aldar, Abu Dhabi's best-known developer.

> **Or two homes instead of one.** AED 5m also covers two 2-bedroom apartments at Tara Park, around AED 2.4-2.7m each. Two rents, and the freedom to sell one without selling both.

Prices from developer releases and current listings, November 2026. Indicative and subject to availability.

◆ THE DUBAI OPTION, AND WHERE I'D START

Palm Springs - Nakheel, Jebel Ali

Dubai's newest family community, launched on 9 November next to Palm Jebel Ali: 977 townhouses and villas for around 50,000 residents.

3-BED TOWNHOUSE
2,326 sq ft from AED 3.8m

PAYMENT PLAN 60/40
10% on booking, 50% in six payments between April 2027 and May 2029, 40% when you receive the keys - AED 2.28m before handover on a 3-bed

READY
October 2030

WHY PEOPLE LIKE IT
Nakheel's name, and more space for the money than anything else in this guide

WHAT TO WEIGH UP
More money paid before handover, a later finish, and a brand-new area in a city completing more homes than it has in years

There are other good options in Dubai beyond Palm Springs, and I'm happy to share them. But as the numbers on the first page show, Abu Dhabi is probably the safer investment right now.

Three good homes at around AED 4m, side by side

	PALM SPRINGS · DUBAI	MAN CITY YAS · ABU DHABI	BASHAYER · ABU DHABI
What you get	3-bed townhouse, 2,326 sq ft	3-bed townhouse, ~2,230 sq ft	3-bed beachfront apartment, ~2,000 sq ft
Price	AED 3.8m	AED 4.25m	from ~AED 3.6m
Price per sq ft	~AED 1,630	~AED 1,910	~AED 1,760
Paid before keys	AED 2.28m (60%)	AED 1.49m (35%)	AED 1.8m (50%)
Ready	October 2030	Late 2029	2029
What's there today	A new masterplan	Ferrari World, Yas Mall, the F1 circuit	Surf park, velodrome, beach - all open

> **WHERE I'D START**
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> Palm Springs gives you the most space for your money, and it's a good product. But if I were in your position, I'd start in Abu Dhabi. You'd keep up to AED 800,000 more in your pocket until the keys arrive, the home would be ready around a year sooner, and you'd be buying in a market where far more people are arriving than homes are being built. Dubai is a strong market too - it's simply at a different stage, with a lot of new supply arriving at the same time.

What happens next

1
Meet and discuss what you'd like the property to do for you

2
Get the actual unit details on the ones we like - availability, exact prices, floor plans

3
Decide from there whether it makes sense

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Prices and figures indicative as of November 2026, based on developer releases, regulator data and current listings (Palm Springs: Nakheel launch pack, 9 November 2026); subject to availability and change. Not financial advice.